When a variable or property is defined but doesn't have a value, then it has the special value `null`. The value `null` is the only value with `typeof null` in CoffeeScript. You might ask what `null` is good for—that's a good question. You see, the `null` value isn't a value you want. Instead, it usually means something has gone wrong. Remember the existential operator used to determine if a variable is either `undefined` or `null`?

```
roundSquare?
# false
```

Well, this existential operator can also be combined with the dot operator and the assignment operator. In this section you'll learn about these additional uses of the existential operator and how they help you live with `null`.

7.3.1. Null soak

Imagine you're writing an application that takes information about users and displays it on a web page. The information for a given user is in an object:

```
user =
  name:
    title: 'Mr'
    first: 'Data'
    last: 'Object'
  contact:
    phone:
      home: '555 2234'
      mobile: '555 7766'
    email:
      primary: 'mrdataobject@coffeescriptinaction.com'
```

How do you access the home phone number for this user?

```
user.contact.phone.home
# '555 2234'
```

Suppose that some of the user data is missing or incomplete. For example, consider a user who doesn't have any contact information: